TOP100 AFRICA FUTURE LEADERS · CLASS OF 2026 · BEYOND RECOGNITION

BLOOM

Positioning Yourself for World-Class Opportunities

From Potential to Purpose, Visibility and Global Impact

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BEFORE WE BEGIN · A SHORT FILM

Meet Cynthia.

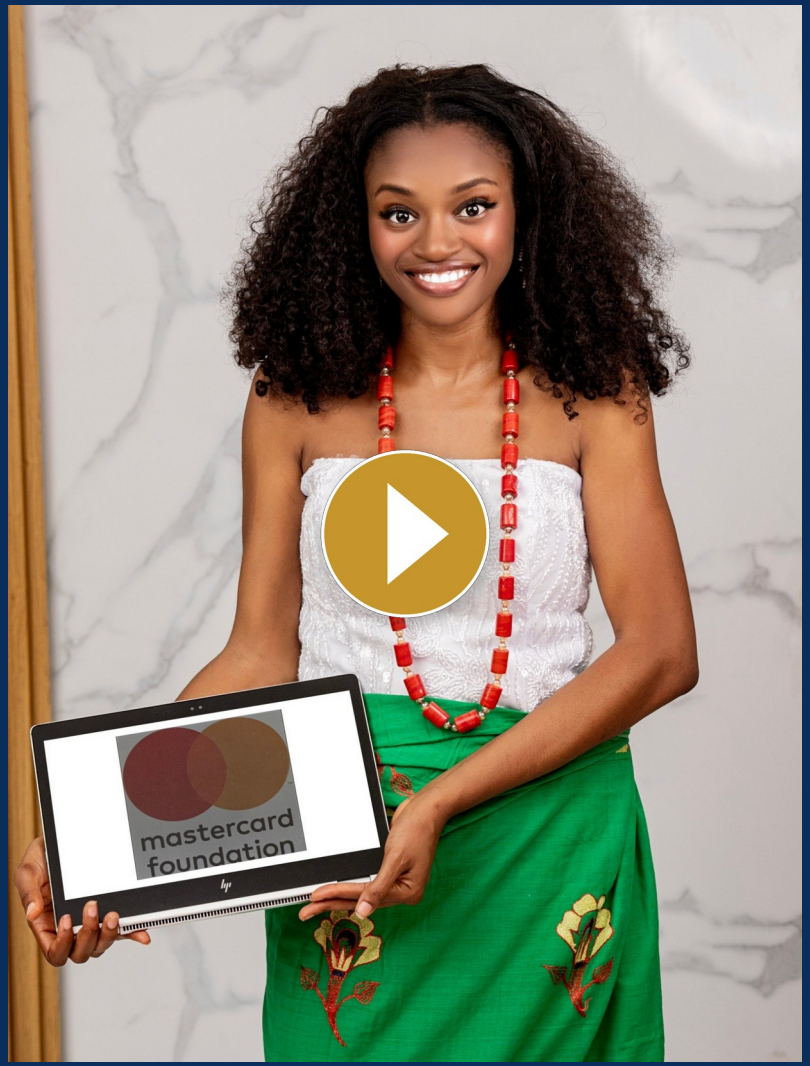
In place of a spoken introduction, a short film tells the story: from Nigeria to the University of Oxford, as narrated by Channels TV.

Watch my Channels TV feature

Click the link, or the film card, to play. Internet connection required.



As seen on Channels Television.



It all started with a dream...

MY CHILDHOOD INSPIRATION

A girl who believed in herself, chased her dreams, and changed her world.













> *There is no limit to what we, as women, can accomplish.* - **Elle Woods**

From dreaming with Elle Woods to living my own story, I chose to **believe in my dreams**, even when no one else had.

WHERE IT BEGAN

Childhood & Academic Foundations

Raised in a home where engineering, the arts and entrepreneurship met, and where five fierce, soft-hearted sisters and remarkable parents made ambition feel ordinary.

Excellence was never framed as talent. It was the predictable outcome of effort, self-belief and love, repeated daily.

By the end of secondary school the pattern was set: valedictorian, and a promise to keep going.

“I was raised to see excellence as a consequence of effort.”

Valedictorian

Secondary school

Valedictorian

University of Nigeria

Five sisters

One fearless village



Paris. Dreaming beyond borders, always.

THE OPPORTUNITY PARADOX

What if the opportunities you dream of are not beyond your reach, but beyond your current positioning?

- Capability alone does not guarantee access.
- Structural barriers are real, and naming them is honest.
- Positioning is the one lever fully in your hands.



Recognition opens a door. Positioning walks through it.

Choices, Challenges, Lessons

01

Physics & Astronomy

First Class at UNN. Lesson: excellence is a currency, spend it on hard doors.

02

Energy & aviation

Offshore and onshore engineering. Lesson: transferable skills travel farther than titles.

03

Oxford, funded

Mastercard Foundation and Norman & Ivy-Lloyd Scholarship. Lesson: fit and evidence beat luck.

04

NGIS Foundation

A platform for others. Lesson: access multiplies when it is shared.

05

Top100 and beyond

Recognition came. Lesson: what you build beyond the award is what counts.

THE SIGNATURE FRAMEWORK

The BLOOM Model

B

THE ROOTS

Build Your Foundation

Skills, evidence and credibility before prestige.

L

THE SEED

Leverage Your Uniqueness

Your story becomes a differentiated value proposition.

O

THE SUNLIGHT

Own Your Visibility

Be discoverable: profile, portfolio, relationships.

O

THE GROWTH

Open Doors Through Action

Research, tailor, apply, collaborate, iterate.

M

THE BLOOM

Multiply Your Impact

Turn access into contribution and opportunity for others.

From seed to full bloom: we will return to this model at every transition tonight.

Credibility Before Prestige

- Map your transferable skills across every role you have held.
- Gather evidence: results, outcomes and projects.
- Audit your growth areas honestly, then close them deliberately.
- Let your record speak before your ambition does.

THE EVIDENCE TEST

Generic: *"Hardworking team player, passionate about energy."* **Credible:** *"Petroleum engineering professional with onshore and offshore experience across prospecting, development and downstream access."*



Roots grow in the field, not on paper.

Fit, Not Merely Credentials

Your background, lived experience and achievements are not a disadvantage to explain away. Translated well, they are a value proposition no one else can copy.

GENERIC *"I am passionate about sustainability and looking for opportunities."*

STRONGER *"I bring [specific skills] and evidence of [results] to [problem or sector], and I am seeking [type of opportunity] where I can contribute [specific value]."*

Rehearse it until it is a confident, 30-second spoken value proposition.



Heritage is not a footnote. It is the headline.

Scholarship & Fellowship Positioning

- Check eligibility and mission fit before spending time on an application.
- Map every selection criterion to concrete, verifiable evidence.
- Build one coherent narrative: motivation, preparation, leadership, contribution.
- Tailor essays and CV to the programme; quantify only what you can verify.
- Choose referees who know your work, and give them context and time.
- Track deadlines, documents, submission status and follow-ups.

No single formula guarantees selection. Evidence simply improves your odds.



The result of a checklist, worked patiently.

THE MINDSET SHIFT

Not “I deserve this.”

“Here is the evidence of fit and contribution.”

01 **Motivation** Why this path, told truthfully.

02 **Preparation** The record that shows you are ready.

03 **Leadership** Where others rose because you acted.

04 **Contribution** What the programme gains by choosing you.



The four parts of your story.

Make Your Work Discoverable

A clear profile and portfolio

Show evidence and outcomes, not adjectives.

Alumni and sector communities

Join with intent; contribute before you ask.

Thoughtful informational conversations

Specific, brief and respectful of people's time.

Referral relationships

Built through contribution, never transactions.

A MESSAGE THAT OPENS DOORS

"Hello [Name], I appreciated your work on [specific project]. I am developing experience in [relevant area] and would value 15 minutes to learn how you approached [specific question]. I understand if your schedule does not permit it. Thank you."

Specific. Brief. Easy to say yes to.

The Global Career Pipeline

01 Target

Choose roles and sectors deliberately.

02 Research

Study the organisations you admire.

03 Close gaps

Name your skill gaps, then close them.

04 Build evidence

Projects and results that prove readiness.

05 Connect

Thoughtful conversations, not cold blasts.

06 Tailor

CV and interview stories fit the role.

07 Apply

Submit the well-matched applications.

08 Iterate

Reflect on outcomes and go again.

Interviews are won in preparation: researched fit, tailored stories, practised delivery.

Doors Open for Those Who Knock

- Research and prioritise opportunities against your own goals.
- Submit tailored applications, never recycled ones.
- Seek feedback after every outcome, win or lose.
- Initiate collaborations and small projects without waiting for permission.

“Someone has to get in, even at a sub four percent acceptance rate. So, why not you?”



The news you make when you keep knocking.

From Idea to Community Value

Nigerian Girl in STEM began as one idea in one notebook. Multiplication, not recognition, made it a movement.

01 **Pilot a small, testable project**

Start where you are, with what you have.

02 **Collaborate and share ownership**

Movements outlive founders when others lead too.

03 **Document results and tell the story**

Evidence attracts partners, funding and trust.

04 **Build sustainable pathways for others**

Mentorship, scholarships and open doors behind you.



STEM outreach and pad drives: access turned into contribution, one classroom at a time.

What Multiplied Impact Looks Like











Classrooms reached, dignity restored, and a generation shown what is possible.

YOUR TURN · RIGHT NOW

The 60-Second Opportunity Audit

01

What is one strength I can demonstrate with evidence?

02

What real problem could I help solve?

03

Who might help me learn, collaborate or gain access?

04

What one action will I complete within seven days?

Write your four answers down tonight. They are the seed of your next application.

YOUR TAKEAWAY TOOLKIT

The 30-Day BLOOM Challenge

WEEK 1

Audit

List five skills, three evidenced achievements and two target opportunity categories.

WEEK 2

Position

Revise your bio and CV; prepare one tailored application narrative.

WEEK 3

Connect

Start three thoughtful conversations; identify one collaborator or mentor.

WEEK 4

Act

Submit one well-matched application or launch a small, testable initiative. Reflect.

This slide is your toolkit. Screenshot it, and start this week.

THE BLOOM RECAP

B Your potential is the seed.

L Your skills are the roots.

O Your relationships shape the environment.

O Your actions drive growth.

M Your impact gives that growth meaning.

Recognition may open a door. What you build and contribute determines what happens beyond it.

THANK YOU · CLASS OF 2026

Don’t just seek opportunities.

Position yourself to grow, create and BLOOM.

Then step into your own world-class era.

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